Memo: Strategies to Maintain Public Support for Energy Projects

TO: Antora Energy | **FROM:** Vilas Annavarapu | **DATE:** November 3, 2026

Executive Summary

Project developers often build goodwill with jobs, taxes, and training programs. These benefits are necessary but not enough to keep a social license to operate. Transparency, safety, and trust are needed to keep projects on schedule and retain public support.

This memo outlines the public and policy backlash to Archer-Daniels-Midland's (ADM) response to an underground CO2 leak in Decatur, Illinois. Though carbon sequestration and Antora's battery products are different, there are relevant takeaways for quality public engagement. Goodwill from policymakers and the public helps a young company like Antora build a strong brand and leverage the success of early projects to enable new deployments. This memo offers the following recommendations: 1) prioritize a culture of company safety and accountability, 2) disclose safety anomalies early, and 3) maintain long-standing relationships with community groups.

Background

Class VI is the EPA permit category for wells that inject CO2 into a deep formation for long-term storage. Permits require monitoring of the storage zone and the formations around it. If CO2 leaking from a Class VI well reached an underground source of drinking water, it could lower the water's pH, which can dissolve metals such as arsenic and lead from aquifer rock. Brine leaking alongside the CO2 could also raise the water's salinity.

At the ADM Class VI well in Decatur, a corroded monitoring well resulted in brine and CO2 moving into a rock layer where injection fluids are not permitted. Sampling in 2024 confirmed CO2 near 5,000 feet underground; ADM estimated about 4,000 metric tons escaped. No drinking water was contaminated. EPA's investigation found ADM did not follow their own emergency plans and storage monitoring protocols. EPA required corrective action without a monetary penalty, but reserved the right if corrective actions were not taken. ADM resumed injection August 29, 2025.

The public learned of the leak about six months after ADM's detection. At that time, ADM finalized a 99-year easement– access to the subsurface without ownership– to expand areas where it can store CO2, including beneath Lake Decatur. Council member David Horn has said he would have voted against the easement had he known, and that several colleagues likely would have changed their votes. At a January 2026 city-hosted forum, 60+ residents attended and most speakers opposed the easement. Residents describe ADM reaching out to landowners by mail at least twice offering financial compensation to allow construction beneath their land. One resident details an offer of $15,000. After news of the leak, a previously failed bill in the Illinois legislature to ban CO2 storage under the Mahomet Aquifer passed (SB 1723) despite organized industry opposition.

ADM's partnership with the Google-backed Broadwing Energy Center is estimated to quadruple Decatur's CO2 injection rate to about 2 million tons per year. Opponents want the storage ban for the Mahomet Aquifer to be extended to Lake Decatur. The easement is unlikely to be overturned, but local frustration and growing opposition to data centers and their power sources could slow the Broadwing project.

Recommendations for Project Developers

ADM's delayed disclosure of its 2024 leak fueled backlash and helped pass a ban on CO2 storage under the Mahomet Aquifer, which prevents future business opportunity. Further, attempts to pay landowners for subsurface rights were met with resistance over safety concerns.

1. Maintain a strong culture of safety, transparency, and collective responsibility

ADM's failure to disclose the leak only after the council approved the 99-year easement makes the delay look strategic. ADM continued to inject CO2 despite monitoring systems not working and did not execute on their own emergency plans. **For Antora:** Antora should have a strong internal culture of safety and accountability. That commitment should be clear to the public. Antora should have internal operating procedures to communicate safety anomalies with local government partners and relevant community groups as soon as possible.

2. Executives and community relations: do not rely on material benefits to earn public buy-in.

ADM is Decatur's largest employer and offers jobs, training programs, and compensation for underground access, yet many residents still oppose the easement. Even a resident in favor said, "I'm not saying you trade health for good paying job." Safety outweighs economic benefits. This concern is sharper for unfamiliar technologies like CO2 storage or thermal batteries. **For Antora:** Antora should partner with local schools to demonstrate how their technology works and be present at community events where they can answer questions from the public about its safety.

3. Community relations leads: build channels before problems occur.
Antora's website does not outline a clear safety plan. Even if the odds of an anomaly are low, communities should know how the company would respond. **For Antora:** Antora should publish a public safety page on their website and designate a local liaison for community engagement. The Process Safety Engineer, with the communications team, should publish an emergency management summary for each project site. It should name the local contact and brief local fire departments.

Conclusion
At Decatur, a monitoring well was the technical weak point, but delayed disclosure caused the lasting damage to community trust. This prevents future business opportunities. Antora should treat safety systems as critical infrastructure and tell communities early to reduce both technical and project risk.

Sources: EPA final order (Aug 13, 2025) · EPA proposed order · EPA responsiveness summary · ADM timeline · Grist/WBEZ · Capitol News Illinois · E&E News: 24 wells · Taxpayers for Common Sense · WAND · NewsChannel 20 · Change.org petition · IPM: SB 1723 · 25 News: industry opposition · Google blog: Broadwing